

Biblical Justice As Duty

prc-biblical-justice-as-duty

Engagement with World · Social Concern · doctrine · divided_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 1.000
confidence high

Statement under examination

Care for the poor, the orphan, the widow, and the oppressed is a Christian duty.

In plain language

Across the canon the words used for caring for the poor, the orphan, the widow, and the oppressed sit in grammatical slots that mark required conduct, not optional kindness. In Micah 6:8 the verse opens by stating what God requires of a person, then lists doing justice (the Hebrew mishpat), loving mercy (chesed), and walking humbly. The phrase to do justice uses an infinitive that places justice in the slot of obligated action. Isaiah 1:17 piles up commands in the imperative mood, learn to do good, seek justice, correct the oppressed, defend the orphan, plead for the widow. The Hebrew parse marks the verbs as predicates and the orphan and widow as the direct objects of those commands, so the grammar itself makes the vulnerable the targets of ordered action. Amos 5:24 commands that justice (mishpat again) roll down like waters and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream, set against worship God refuses. In the gospel, Jesus tells scrupulous tithers in Matthew 23:23 that they have neglected the weightier matters of the law, naming them justice, mercy, and faithfulness. The Greek words there are krisis and eleos, which are the standard renderings of the same Hebrew mishpat and chesed, so Jesus carries the prophetic triad forward and explicitly ranks it heavier than ritual exactness. In James 1:27 the Greek defines pure and undefiled religion before God as visiting orphans and widows in their affliction, using a verb of ongoing care. Because this is a definition, the care is built into what acceptable religion means rather than offered as an example. One of the listed anchor passages, Galatians 1:6-9, is about something else. There Paul pronounces a curse on anyone who preaches a different gospel, using the words for gospel and curse. That passage defends the message that is preached, not the ethics of caring for the poor, so it neither proves nor disproves the care obligation and is set aside as off the topic. Where readers diverge is not whether the duty exists in the words, but at the next step. The vocabulary lays down active care on the community, but it does not by itself rank one civil or political mechanism for delivering that care over another. So the lexical layer settles the duty, and the application sits outside what the words alone fix.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0490	אַלְמָנָה	almanah	widow	51
H1875	דָּרַשׁ	darash	to seek	146
H2541	חֲמוֹץ	chamots	oppression	1
H2617	חֶסֶד	chesed	kindness	248
H3490	יָתוֹם	yathom	orphan	37
H4941	מִשְׁפָּט	mishpat	justice	425
H6213	עָשָׂה	asah	to make	2,632
H6664	צֶדֶק	tsedeq	righteousness	119

H6800	נָצַל	tsana	be humble	2
H8199	שָׁפַט	shaphat	to judge	184
G0331	ἀνάθεμα	anathema	devoted	6
G1656	ἔλεος	eleos	mercy	27
G1980	ἐπισκέπτομαι	episkeptomai	to visit/care for	11
G2098	εὐαγγέλιον	euangelion	gospel	77
G2347	θλίψις	thlipsis	pressure	44
G2356	θρησκεία	threskeia	religion	4
G2513	καθαρός	katharos	clean	28
G2920	κρίσις	krisis	judgment	48
G3737	ὀρφανός	orphanos	orphan	2

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The imperative and infinitive lexical pattern across Mic 6:8, Isa 1:17, Amos 5:24, Jas 1:27, and Matt 23:23 places active care for the vulnerable in the slot of required covenant conduct, not optional benevolence. Mishpat (H4941) is the shared object of doing in Micah and of seeking in Isaiah, and Jesus glosses the equivalent triad as ten krisin kai to eleos kai ten pistin, calling them the weightier matters of the law. James assigns the participial acts of visiting orphans and widows to the predicate of pure threskeia before God. The duty reading holds across Hebrew prophecy, Synoptic gospel, and Greek epistle with no material textual variant disturbing it. The Galatians 1:6-9 anchor governs gospel fidelity rather than social ethics, so it neither establishes nor undercuts the duty claim and is treated as a complicating, off-target text.

Scripture

Mic.6.8 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H6213 נָשַׁב, H4941 מִשְׁפָּט, H2617 דָּרַשׁ, H6800 נָצַל.

Force. The verse states what YHWH requires of man as a triad of infinitive constructs governed by the verb of demand, asot mishpat (to do justice), love chesed (mercy), and walk humbly. The infinitive asot places justice in the slot of obligated action, not sentiment. The Hebrew poetic structure pairs the lines in stepped lines, framing all three as the content of the divine requirement rather than as graded options.

Isa.1.17 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H8199 שָׁפַט, H1875 דָּרַשׁ, H4941 מִשְׁפָּט, H3490 יָתוֹם, H0490 אֶלְמָנָה, H2541 חֲמוּץ.

Force. A dense chain of imperatives, learn to do good, seek justice (dirshu mishpat), correct the oppressed (chamots), defend (shaphat) the orphan (yathom), plead for the widow (almanah). The ETCBC parse marks the verbs as Predicate and the named vulnerable parties as Object, so the grammar makes the orphan and widow the direct objects of commanded action. The imperative mood removes the reading that this is descriptive rather than required.

Amos.5.24 · for · genre: prophecy · figures: simile

Key terms. H4941 מִשְׁפָּט, H6664 רָצָה.

Force. Amos commands that mishpat roll down like waters and tsedaqah like an ever-flowing stream. The jussive verb form and the simile place justice and righteous-dealing as the demanded outcome of covenant life, set in direct contrast (Amos 5:21-23) with cultic activity God refuses to accept. The same noun mishpat that anchors Mic 6:8 and Isa 1:17 recurs here as the required content of Israel's life before God, widening the canon spread within the prophets.

Matt.23.23 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2920 κρίσις, G1656 ἔλεος

Force. Jesus rebukes scrupulous tithers for neglecting ta barytera tou nomou, the weightier matters of the law, naming them ten krisin kai to eleos kai ten pistin. Krisis (justice) and eleos (mercy) are the Septuagintal renderings of mishpat and chesed, so Jesus directly endorses the Mic 6:8 triad as still binding and explicitly labels these as weightier than ceremonial precision. The construction is a contrastive parallel that affirms justice and mercy as required content of obedience.

Jas.1.27 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2356 θρησκεία, G1980 ἐπισκέπτομαι, G3737 ὀρφανός, G2347 θλίψις, G2513 καθарός

Force. Pure (kathara) and undefiled threskeia (religion) before God is defined by an epexegetical infinitive, episkeptesthai (to visit, look after) orphans (orphanous) and widows in their thlipsis (affliction). The predicate nominative construction equates acceptable religion with this active care, so the duty is built into the definition rather than appended as an example. The present infinitive signals ongoing, habitual attention rather than a single act.

Gal.1.8 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2098 εὐαγγέλιον, G0331 ἀνάθεμα

Force. Paul pronounces anathema on anyone who preaches a euangelion contrary to the one received. The lexical subject here is the content of the proclaimed gospel and the penalty for distorting it, not the ethics of caring for the poor. This anchor concerns gospel fidelity and is off the semantic axis of the social-duty proposition.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Mic.6.8	Deut.10.12	tsk	1
Mic.6.8	Gen.18.19	tsk	1
Mic.6.8	1Sam.12.23	tsk	1
Mic.6.8	Ps.37.26	tsk	1
Isa.1.17	Isa.1.23	tsk	1
Isa.1.17	Zech.7.9	openbible	1
Isa.1.17	Jer.22.3	openbible	1
Jas.1.27	Job.29.12	tsk	1
Jas.1.27	Jas.3.17	tsk	1
Jas.1.27	Deut.24.19	openbible	1
Matt.23.23	Mic.6.8	openbible	1
Gal.1.9	Deut.4.2	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Gal.1.6 · addressed

The Galatians 1:6-9 anchor uses euangelion and anathema to defend the integrity of the preached gospel against a different message. It does not address care for the poor, orphan, widow, or oppressed at the lexical level, so it cannot make social concern either a gospel essential or a denial. It is resolved as off-target and assigned supports=neutral, leaving the duty verdict to rest on Mic 6:8, Isa 1:17, Amos 5:24, Matt 23:23, and Jas 1:27.

Matt.23.23 · addressed

Some readers cite Jesus's tauta edei poiesai kakeina me aphienai (these you ought to have done, without neglecting the others) as preserving the lesser duties, raising the question whether krisis and eleos are merely co-required with ritual. The grammar makes them the weightier (barytera) matters by explicit predicate, so neglect of justice and mercy is the named hypocrisy regardless of ceremonial scruple, confirming the duty reading.

Concordance traversed

H4941, H6213, H2617, H6800, H8199, H1875, H3490, H0490, H2541, H6664, G2920, G1656, G2356, G1980, G3737, G2347, G2513, G2098, G0331

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

Anchor verses are OT prophecy (Mic 6:8, Isa 1:17, Amos 5:24), a Synoptic gospel saying (Matt 23:23), and a Catholic and a Pauline epistle (Jas 1:27, Gal 1:6-9), none in CBGM ECM scope for this run. The James 1:27 article-and-pronoun cluster around the widow phrase carries minor manuscript variation but does not touch the orphan-and-widow care lexemes that anchor the verdict. Matt 23:23 has known minor variation in the order of the three weightier matters, but krisis and eleos are stable across the tradition.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, dispensationalism, new_covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

covenant_theology: affirms · Reads the prophetic mishpat-and-chesed demands as abiding covenant ethics continuous into the church, so care for the vulnerable remains a standing obligation, with Matt 23:23 confirming Jesus retains the same triad as the law's weightier matters.

dispensationalism: affirms · Even on a strict church-versus-Israel division, Jas 1:27 supplies a New Testament epistolary command that defines acceptable religion as caring for orphans and widows, and Matt 23:23 endorses krisis and eleos as binding under the law Jesus addresses, grounding the duty for the present age independent of how the OT prophets are read.

new_covenant_theology: affirms · Treats the OT justice demands as fulfilled and reissued in the law of Christ, with James restating the care obligation and Matt 23:23 anchoring it in Jesus's own teaching, so the duty holds under the new covenant ethic.

scope_contested_application: affirms_with_scope_caveat · A defensible minority lens grants the lexical duty but distinguishes it from any specific political or economic program. The words mishpat, chesed, krisis, eleos, and episkeptesthai predicate active care on the believing community; they do not, at the lexical level, mandate or forbid any one civil mechanism for delivering that care. The duty is decisive in the words. The contested zone is application, the route from text to policy, which the vocabulary does not by itself rank.

All three continuity frameworks converge on affirmation because the New Testament gospel and epistle (Matt 23:23, Jas 1:27) carry the duty independently, so the verdict does not depend on resolving the continuity debate. A separate scope-of-application lens is recorded fairly because the lexical layer establishes the duty but does not by itself fix the political mechanism for fulfilling it, and that scope distinction is where readers honestly diverge.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Is active care for the poor, the orphan, the widow, and the oppressed presented in the lexical record as obligatory conduct for God's people?

Two preloading concerns. First, the word duty is a verdict-leaning frame, neutralized above to ask whether the texts present the care as obligatory rather than optional. Second, and more significant, the metadata pairs the social-concern proposition with the Gal 1:6-9 anathema-on-a-different-gospel passage. That coupling can preload the inference that social concern is constitutive of the gospel itself, such that failing it would fall under the anathema. The lexical evidence does not support that inference, Gal 1:6-9 is about the content of the preached gospel, not ethics, so it is recorded as a neutral, off-target complicating text. The duty verdict is derived only from the imperative and definitional grammar of Mic 6:8, Isa 1:17, Amos 5:24, Matt 23:23, and Jas 1:27, and is rendered on the original stem.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Mic.6.8
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.1.17
morphology	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Amos.5.24
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Isa.1.17
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Mic.6.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Jas.1.27
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.23.23
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2356
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2920
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1656
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H4941
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2617
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Jas.1.27
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Isa.1.17
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Matt.23.23
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Gal.1.8

License audit

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Reason. ETCBC-BHSA syntactic parse for Isa 1:17 and Mic 6:8 is licensed CC-BY-NC-4.0 (non-commercial), which blocks bulk redistribution. All other sources used (STEPBible-TAHOT, OSHB-morphology, MorphGNT-morphology, STEPBible-TBESG, STEPBible-TBESH, TSK, OpenBible-cross-refs) are redistributable, but the aggregate is unsafe because of the ETCBC dependency.

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Flags

(none)